

CHANGE OF GUARD ON THE CARDS

Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli may get their **final shot at World Cup glory** this June, with the T20 WC marking the start of a major transition in Indian cricket.

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Leave it to a senior statesman to remind us that Indian cricket can not only be a thing of beauty but also a thrill-a-minute heartbreak. Indian fans needed some relief from the team's oft-criticised inability to go harder and faster in the early exchanges during the PowerPlay, and that's exactly what captain Rohit Sharma offered as the curtains fell on 2023.

In October, at the ODI World Cup in India, there was the 36-year-old Rohit, bullying the opposition new-ball attacks with aggressive strokeplay and outsize swagger. Meanwhile, his teammate and bona fide great, Virat Kohli, hit a record 50th ODI century, surpassing his idol Sachin Tendulkar, who watched on in the crowd during India's World Cup semifinal win against New Zealand.

As the Men in Blue barged into the final, the fans wondered, with zealous optimism at times, if this was the year India ended the decade-long wait for an ICC trophy. In Rohit and Kohli, there were two men, aided by a

skilled and buoyant XI, determined to bring to life that dream.

But we are limited creatures, despite our pretensions to the contrary. Even as an entire nation resisted the temptation to acknowledge the existence of a possibility that obediently contradicted their experiences of it, Pat Cummins and Australia gave a rude awakening, "silencing a big crowd," en route to a record sixth World Cup title by beating India in the final.

So, as the calendar flips to 2024, India's pursuit of elusive ICC silverware is back to square one. Rohit's men will have yet another crack in four months at the 2024 T20 World Cup, which will be jointly hosted by the USA and West Indies, with the final to be staged in Barbados on June 29.

The West Indies and USA earned automatic entry by being hosts, with the latter to play in the tournament for the first time. England, Pakistan, New Zealand, India, Australia, South Africa, the Netherlands, and Sri Lanka secured their places by finishing in the top eight of the T20 World Cup in 2022.

Afghanistan and Bangladesh, as

the next best T20I teams in rankings, joined the roster, along with sides determined by regional qualifiers. Ireland and Scotland secured spots from the European section, while Papua New Guinea advanced from the East Asia-Pacific Qualifier. Canada, set for their tournament debut, earned a spot through the Americas Qualifier. Nepal and Oman emerged as Asian qualifiers, and Namibia and Uganda completed the lineup by succeeding in the African Qualifier.

It seems likely that both Rohit and Kohli will be part of the 2024 World Cup after the duo was named in the squad for the Afghanistan T20I series at home, ending their more than year-long absence from the shortest format.

This was also India's last T20I series before the T20 World Cup in June, and ergo, a final chance to let the likes of Rinku Singh and Tilak Varma make their cases. However, the inclusion of Rohit and Virat could likely result in there being no room for the aforementioned youngsters.

The fact that India has failed to discover any fortune in T20 World Cups could be blamed both on a lack of adaptability to a super-attacking